WHAT IF?! EP 08

FREE CHEAT SHEET
you commented LAUGH

The Contagion Cheat Sheet



Why laughs spread, and how to start one. The science in seven findings, a field guide, and a quiz: are you patient zero of your group chat?

WHY LAUGHS SPREAD

1. **Your face rehearses it.** Hearing a laugh lights up your premotor cortex, so your face gets ready to join in. The response is stronger for positive sounds (Warren et al. 2006).
2. **We laugh 30 times more with other people** than alone (Robert Provine).
3. **It is rarely about jokes.** Most conversational laughter follows ordinary remarks, not punchlines, and speakers laugh more than listeners. The famous example: "see you later".
4. **Recorded laughs work.** Laugh tracks make jokes seem funnier (Smyth and Fuller 1972; Scott lab 2019). CBS engineer Charley Douglass built the "laff box" of tape loops in the early 1950s.
5. **It is older than language.** Apes laugh when tickled, and sound analysis traces laughter back at least 10 to 16 million years. Tickled rats give ultrasonic calls at about 50 kHz.
6. **Your laugh gives you away.** Listeners in 24 societies could tell from a clip whether two people laughing were friends or strangers (Bryant et al. 2016).
7. **People once paid to hear it.** The 1922 OKeh Laughing Record, just people laughing, became a US best-seller and now sits in the Library of Congress registry.

HOW TO START A LAUGH (my reading of the research)

Get in a room.
Together beats alone by about 30 to 1.

Skip the punchline.
Warm, ordinary remarks trigger most laughs.

Go first.
Speakers laugh more, and a positive sound catches harder.

Borrow a laugh.
Recorded laughter makes jokes seem funnier.

Sources Warren et al., J Neurosci 2006 (Nature News) · Provine, APA Monitor Jun 2006 · NPR Jul 2019 (laugh tracks); Hackaday 2025 (Douglass) · Davila-Ross et al. 2009; Ishiyama and Brecht, Science 2016 · Bryant et al., PNAS 2016 · Library of Congress (OKeh Laughing Record)

Patient zero of your group chat?

Five questions. Tick the ones that sound like you.



- ☐ +2 **You laugh more with people than alone.**
  Everyone does: about 30 times more, per Provine.
- ☐ +2 **You laugh at ordinary remarks, not just jokes.**
  Most conversational laughs follow "see you later", not punchlines.
- ☐ +2 **You laugh while you are the one talking.**
  Speakers laugh more than listeners.
- ☐ +2 **A stranger's giggle makes your face twitch.**
  Your premotor cortex is already rehearsing it.
- ☐ +2 **You have laughed first, then asked what was funny.**
  Contagion in action. No study needed.

0-2	4-6	8	10
Quiet carrier	Group-chat gremlin	Walking laugh track	Patient zero

WHEN LAUGHING WASN'T FUN: TANGANYIKA, 1962

30 Jan	18 Mar	Apr-May	June	Later
Three girls at a mission boarding school start laughing and cannot stop	95 of 159 pupils affected. The school closes	A nearby village: 217 people in 34 days	Another girls' school: 48 affected	Reportedly about 1,000 people, 14 schools. Over a year in all



Attacks lasted from a few hours to 16 days (about a week on average) and came with crying, fainting and rashes. The teachers were not affected. Doctors (Rankin and Philip, 1963) found no infection or toxin. Researchers read it as stress, a mass psychogenic illness, in children under heavy pressure. The numbers beyond the first school are reportedly from one secondary source. These were real people in distress, so we do not laugh at them.

DO NOT CONFUSE IT WITH

"Laughing death" (kuru). That was a prion disease in Papua New Guinea, spread through funeral cannibalism. Symptoms sometimes included uncontrollable laughing, but it was not a laughter epidemic.



So why do sitcoms use laugh tracks? They do make jokes seem funnier. Hearing a laugh primes your face to join in, though no source says that is why studios started.

Sources Wikipedia and owaahh.com: Tanganyika laughter epidemic · Rankin and Philip, Cent Afr J Med 1963; Hempelmann, Humor 2007 · face2faceafrica.com (1962 schools) · hekint.org 2019 (kuru history) · Discover Magazine; NPR 2019 (laugh tracks)